



Resistance Readiness: Wartime Edition

How to Protect Yourself
When the Government
Uses War Powers
Against Its Own People

From The American Pamphleteer's War Room Series

Field-tested tools for organized resistance

1. Get Local, Stay Local

Because national power won't save you—but your neighbors might.

Do now:

- **Join or start a local mutual aid group.** These aren't just for groceries and floods—they're democratic infrastructure when formal systems collapse.
- **Know your county government.** Who's your sheriff? Your DA? Your school board? These people *will matter* if federal power starts reaching in.

- **Back your public defenders and legal aid networks.** Fund them, volunteer with them, partner with them. They'll be the front line for detained protestors.

Historical echo: During the Civil Rights Movement, resistance didn't start in the streets—it started in church basements, living rooms, and legal offices.

Local Black churches served as command centers for organizing, training, and mutual protection. Lawyers with the NAACP Legal Defense Fund and local Black bar associations created legal support networks ready to spring into action when arrests came.

Leaders like Ella Baker and Septima Clark built decentralized grassroots systems through groups like the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC) and the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC), which trained everyday people in civil disobedience, legal rights, and nonviolent resistance. Protesters carried contact info for lawyers in their shoes. Community members opened their homes to shelter organizers under threat.

These networks were the difference between isolated action and sustained movement. They didn't just survive repression—they outlasted it.

2. Harden Your Digital Life

Surveillance is already here. Don't make it easy.

Do now:

- Switch to **Signal** or **Session** for messaging. Use **ProtonMail** for sensitive emails. Enable 2FA on everything.
- Stop sharing *everything* on big social platforms. Start building parallel spaces: Substack, encrypted Discords, private email lists.
- Learn to use a **VPN** and consider **Faraday bags** for protests.
- Download important contacts, docs, and guides *offline*—because the internet isn't guaranteed.

Historical echo: In occupied Europe during World War II, resistance movements survived not through high-tech tools, but through ingenuity, paper trails, and human trust.

When power was cut, phones were tapped, and radios jammed, underground networks relied on handwritten notes, coded messages in newspapers, and couriers—often teenagers on bicycles—to carry information between cells.

In France, the *Maquis* used forged documents, secret printing presses, and elaborate dead-drop systems to coordinate sabotage operations and spread anti-Nazi literature. In Poland, the *Armia Krajowa* (Home Army) created entire underground postal systems and schools. In the Netherlands, Jewish families survived thanks to hiding networks supported by farmers, clergy, and ordinary citizens who kept no records—only memories.

These resistance networks were deliberately decentralized so if one person was caught, the whole movement wouldn't collapse. The lesson? **Never rely on a single line of communication, and never assume the system will stay up.**

What they built then, we must build again—with modern tools, but the same unbreakable spirit.

3. Build Parallel Institutions

Democracy doesn't live in D.C.—it lives in us.

Do now:

- Create independent media: newsletters, podcasts, zines. Lift up *your own voice* and those in your community.
- Build alternate economies: cash-based systems, barter, community-supported businesses.
- Start a neighborhood watch—not the cop kind, the *solidarity* kind.

Historical echo: The Black Panther Party wasn't just about protest—it was about *building a parallel system of care and accountability* where the state had failed or turned hostile.

In the late 1960s and early '70s, the Panthers launched more than 60 Survival Programs across the country. They ran free breakfast programs that fed tens of thousands of children before school—because hunger was a form of oppression. They opened community health clinics in cities like Oakland and Chicago to treat everything from tuberculosis to sickle cell anemia—because the government wouldn't. They offered free clothing drives, tutoring, and transportation for the elderly. And perhaps most famously, they organized armed community patrols to monitor police activity and protect Black residents from brutality.

These were not acts of charity. They were acts of **self-determination**. The Panthers showed that mutual aid wasn't just compassionate—it was *revolutionary*. They proved that local

communities could govern, feed, protect, and care for themselves without relying on a state that criminalized their very existence.

That legacy lives on today in grassroots organizers, prison abolitionists, and mutual aid networks. In moments of war or crackdown, parallel institutions are how the people survive—and how resistance thrives.

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4. Join or Form a Resistance Cell

Small groups = resilient organizing.

Do now:

- Connect with 3–5 trusted people. Agree on your shared principles. Set up secure communication.
- Divide roles: media, legal, logistics, protest coordination.
- Practice: drills, surveillance evasion, protest support.

Historical echo: Under Soviet-backed communist rule in Czechoslovakia, dissent was dangerous—but it was also organized.

Czech dissidents like Václav Havel and the writers of *Charter 77* knew they were under constant surveillance. Phones were tapped, mail was read, typewriters were registered, and informants were everywhere. So they built their resistance in **cells**—small, trusted circles of 3–6 people who each worked semi-independently. No one cell had full knowledge of the larger network. That way, if one was infiltrated or arrested, the rest could carry on.

Messages were passed by hand, often hidden in books, laundry, or bread loaves. Banned literature was duplicated in secret by *samizdat*—homemade presses using carbon paper and manual typewriters.

The brilliance of the Czech dissident model wasn't just in secrecy—it was in *distribution*. Every household that held a copy of a banned essay became part of the network. Every reader was a resistor. Over time, these decentralized cells helped shape public opinion, lay the groundwork for peaceful mass protests, and eventually bring down the regime during the 1989 Velvet Revolution.

The lesson? Centralized movements can be decapitated. Distributed ones endure. In a wartime crackdown, don't go big—**go *small and many***. That's how resistance survives long enough to win.

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5. Know the Law—And Your Line in the Sand

You don't need to be a lawyer—but you *do* need to know what's legal, and what's *right*.

Do now:

- Know your rights in protests, in detention, and when approached by federal agents. (Get the ***Legal Tips for High Risk Protestors*** pamphlet.)
- Identify the “line” you won't let them cross—because if we all hold our lines, they can't push us all down.
- Make a plan for arrest. Who will you call? Who will show up? Write it *down* and share it with your cell.

Historical echo: During apartheid in South Africa, resistance was not only organized—it was *prepared*.

Activists and community leaders knew arrest wasn't a matter of *if*, but *when*. So they planned for it. The African National Congress (ANC), United Democratic Front (UDF), and other anti-apartheid groups trained their members in legal rights, detention protocols, and interrogation resistance.

Protesters carried contact numbers for defense lawyers scrawled on paper, memorized, or hidden in shoes and sleeves. Parents made contingency plans for childcare in case of sudden arrest. Communities organized ***rapid response teams*** that could show up at police stations, deliver food to prisoners, or rally outside courthouses.

Legal support was just one part of the infrastructure. Activists built underground communication lines, safe houses, and emergency meeting points. Many who were arrested were already trained in how to endure solitary confinement or resist giving up names under torture. This wasn't paranoia—it was strategy. Because under apartheid, the law was the weapon, and survival required knowing how to disarm it.

The lesson: hope is not a plan. If you know the knock is coming—*prepare*. Arrests don't break movements when the people are ready, resourced, and backed by a network that knows what to do when the state turns violent.

6. Stay Human, Stay Joyful, Stay Loud

Resistance is more than defense—it's a declaration of life.

Do now:

- Make art. Throw dance parties. Cook for the neighborhood. Write letters. Hug hard.
- Don't let them turn you into a fearful, passive subject. That's what they want. Joy is rebellion.

Historical echo: In Nazi-occupied France, the *Maquis*—rural resistance fighters who hid in forests and mountain caves—knew that winning the war wasn't just about sabotage and weapons. It was about *spirit*.

Cut off from their homes, hunted by German soldiers and Vichy collaborators, and surrounded by fear, the Maquis still found ways to celebrate life. They danced under the stars. They played guitars and violins. They recited poetry and staged underground plays. Their camps became *living testaments* to what they were fighting for—not just survival, but freedom, beauty, dignity.

This wasn't escapism. It was rebellion. Every note of music, every line of theater, every shared laugh was a rejection of fascism's attempt to crush the human soul. As one French resister put it, "We were fighting not only to live—but to live *as humans*."

That same spirit pulsed through resistance movements across history: the freedom songs of Selma, the poetry of Palestinian youth, the drag balls during the AIDS crisis. ***Joy is not a distraction—it's a weapon.***

The lesson: Authoritarianism feeds on fear, isolation, and silence. When we gather, create, sing, and dance—we remind each other that we're still alive, still free inside, and still in the fight.

Final Thought:

You don't have to do everything. You just have to *do your part*. Every revolution, every resistance, every democracy that's ever survived—did so because *enough people refused to give up*.

You are not alone. You are not powerless. And you are *not* too late.

Join the Resistance. Share this. Prepare Now.

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